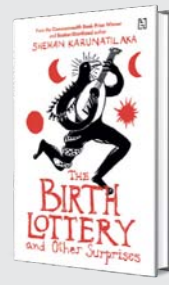
Come October 12, Shehan Karunatilaka could become the first-ever Sri Lankan writer to win the Booker Prize; his novel *Chats with the Dead* (published in the UK as *The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida*) is on the shortlist. His 2010 novel *Chinaman: The Legend of Pradeep Mathew*, is frequently hailed as one of the great novels of the 21st century, and arguably the single greatest work of fiction involving cricket. And like the titular spin bowler of that novel unveils (as commentators are fond of saying) his "full bag of tricks", so too does Karunatilaka with his latest—a collection of short fiction called *The Birth Lottery and Other Surprises*.

In the recently released *Birth Lottery*, stories of 15-20 pages are sandwiched between 'short shorts' of no more than one or two pages. During an interview, Karunatilaka spoke about how he started writing these stories (the oldest was written in 2001): "When I was procrastinating on writing my novel, I would write these longer short stories—two or three a year—as writing exercises. And when I was procrastinating on the longer stories, I would write the really short ones. While putting the collection together, it felt like putting a prog-rock album together, almost, and so I tried to balance the moods." If Karunatilaka saw that he had an experimental story, he would follow it up with something much more traditionally structured.

There really is something for everybody in this collection: stories like 'Easy Tiger' and 'Black Jack' are case studies in the proverbial twist ending (and Karunatilaka really does like to twist the knife in, narratively speaking). 'The Colonials' begins like a *Reader's Digest* joke ("An Englishman, a Dutchman and a Portuguese man walked into a bar") and then unfurls to become a far stranger parable about commerce, greed and one-upmanship. 'The Ceylon Islands' is a clever piece of speculative fiction—a billionaire and his influential diaspora friends come together to set up 'The Ceylon Islands', a highly successful and profitable Sri Lanka-in-miniature that soon becomes a sovereign nation in its own right.



CHATS WITH THE DEAD
by Shehan Karunatilaka
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
₹699; 400 pages



THE BIRTH LOTTERY AND OTHER SURPRISES
by Shehan Karunatilaka
HACHETTE INDIA
₹599; 272 pages

***Chats with the Dead* (*The Seven Moons...* in the UK) and *The Birth Lottery and Other Surprises* represent one of the sharpest writers in the business**

During the interview, Karunatilaka spoke about how he approached this story: "In all of our political discourse, there's the voice of the diaspora. And Sri Lankans abroad (they're everywhere, just like Indians) tend to excel in a way they don't at home. Australia and New Zealand have more female Sri Lankan MPs than we have at home. There's this idea that these people would all come home—Sri Lanka is supposed to be paradise, right?—if we ended the war, the violence. So, the starting point from where I pursued the story was what if all these Sri Lankans abroad form a nation of their own?"

The titular story, 'The Birth Lottery', is, Karunatilaka says, "appeals to nobody, basically". It's a stylistic departure, written in 42 short segments, describing the birth, death and rebirth of a single omniscient narrator in Sri Lanka. Some of these lives are short and brutal, others long and languorous. Together, they make up an oblique history of life as we know it. That's the scale of ambition Karunatilaka has always displayed in his work.

Questions of death, near-death experiences and the afterlife are never too far away in Karunatilaka's fiction: in *Chinaman*, there's a memorable scene where the protagonist, 'WG', has a heart attack and briefly hovers above his own body watching his friends trying to revive him (he survives the heart attack, eventually). And then, of course, there's *Chats with the Dead*, or *The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida*, the novel that's currently on the Booker shortlist. Its photographer protagonist Maali dies right at the beginning of the novel and finds himself in a hilariously bureaucratic afterlife. He knows why he has been killed—he holds a stash of photographs that could "end the war"—but he doesn't know who did the deed. As Karunatilaka clarified during the interview, Maali Almeida was born out of the same (unpublished) manuscript that also led to 'The Birth Lottery'.

"Before *Chats with the Dead*, too, I had been grappling with the idea of writing a ghost story for seven years. It was initially a novel called 'Devil Dance', which ultimately did not work. The character of Maali Almeida was the only one which I retained in *Chats with the Dead*. But there was also a self-contained section towards the end where this ghost looks back upon his 42 lives, which span around 2,500 years."

Together, *Chats with the Dead* and *The Birth Lottery and Other Surprises* represent one of the sharpest, funniest writers in the business having fun with his craft. ■

Aditya Mani Jha